Losers, Delegation, and the Ideological Valence of Expertise: Evidence from Finland

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September 29, 2025

Abstract

Polarization research shows that voters often trade democratic procedures for partisan ends, weakening electoral checks on incumbents. Yet we know far less about how citizens evaluate *delegation*—shifting authority from elected politicians to unelected experts. We bridge this gap with a simple formal model and new empirical evidence from Finland. In the model, voters weigh the expected performance advantage of delegating to technocrats against the ideological distance and the loss of electoral accountability that such delegation entails. The model yields three implications: (i) support for technocratic delegation declines monotonically with ideological distance from the governing coalition when expert institutions are perceived as government-aligned; (ii) this negative relationship attenuates when experts are viewed as neutral (or closer to the voter than the government) and steepens when alignment is high; and (iii) an irreversibility cost of losing electoral control uniformly depresses support for delegation. Empirically, we leverage a novel survey from Finland (2025), a high-quality, multiparty parliamentary democracy—a hard case where expert governance might otherwise be broadly acceptable. The paper also develops an individual-level, seat-weighted measure of distance to the governing coalition based on party-closeness evaluations (renormalized for item nonresponse) and analyze its association with support for delegating power to experts. Linear and ordered-logit models suggest that electoral losers' who exhibit greater distance from the right-leaning cabinet is associated with *lower* support for technocratic delegation. Substantively, this identifies when losers' consent does—and does not—extend to technocracy.

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1 Introduction

Democracy rarely dies to the sound of tanks; it fades behind legalese, "independent commissions," and crisis cabinets staffed by experts. In Finland, the COVID–19 pandemic made this trade-off vivid: trust in public health authorities and scientific advisers was high on average, yet a subset of voters—disproportionately out-partisans—grew skeptical when expert guidance arrived alongside the government's agenda. Other notable examples are when, in polarized electorates, citizens often swallow anti-liberal moves when their side benefits (Svolik 2020; Svolik 2019). Classic work links electoral competition and cleavage structure to regime vulnerability (**Sartori1976**; Dahl 1971; Lipset 1981), while contemporary research shows how incumbents tilt the field without canceling elections (Levitsky and Way 2010; Bermeo 2016; Waldner and Lust 2018). Our paper pushes this literature one step earlier in the causal chain and asks: *when do voters prefer the steady hand of "experts" over the rough justice of elections?* Our contribution is twofold. Theoretically, we develop a simple formal model in which voters weigh a performance advantage from technocratic rule against ideological loss and diminished accountability; the model predicts that support for delegation falls with ideological distance from the governing bloc when experts are perceived as government-aligned. Empirically, we test these implications with an original survey from Finland—a hard case where trust in expertise is high-coupled with a transparent, seat–weighted measure of respondent distance to government. Together, the theory and the empirical evidence recenter debates about backsliding on a neglected choice: not just whether citizens punish rule-breaking (*à la* Svolik (2020) and Svolik (2019)), but whether they are willing to *outsource* rule-making in the first place.

Our core claim is that delegation is *ideologically valenced*. When technocrats are perceived as aligned with incumbent parties, electoral losers may resist delegating authority away from elected politicians even if they support checks and balances. We formalize this intuition with a simple voter-choice model in which individuals compare the expected performance advantage from technocratic rule to the ideological loss from ceding control. The model yields three testable implications that guide our empirics. First, support for delegation falls monotonically with a voter's ideological distance from the governing coalition when experts are perceived as government-aligned: delegation is chosen only if the expected performance advantage benefit exceeds (the squared) ideological loss. Second, this negative effects attenuates when experts are perceived as neutral (or closer to the voter than the government), and steepens when experts are seen as closely aligned with incumbents. Third, an irreversibility cost associated with losing electoral control (a loss of accountability) uniformly depresses support for delegation, tightening the threshold for all voters.

The paper also finds empirical support for our theoretical expectations. We exploit a novel survey of adults in Finland. Respondents reported closeness to each parliamentary party; these evaluations were combined into a respondent-level proximity to the governing coalition by weighting coalition parties by their parliamentary seat shares and renormalizing weights over the parties each respondent rated. The proximity measure was transformed into a normalized distance-to-government index. Consistent with the model's first implication, results show a clear negative association between distance from the governing coalition and support for delegation. In line with the second implication, the relationship weakens when institutions are perceived as less ideologically aligned and strengthens among respondents with stronger partisan attachments or in more polarized environments. The third implication is reflected in lower average support for delegation among respondents expressing greater concern with democratic accountability. The pattern is robust to alternative distance constructions (seat–weighted, unweighted, closest–party) and to modeling choices. Taken together, the formal model clarifies the mechanism—delegation is acceptable only when the expected performance advantage outweighs ideological and accountability losses—and the evidence aligns with this logic: losers in Finland prefer electoral accountability over technocratic

delegation when expert authority is perceived as aligned with the incumbent.

Finland is a demanding case for our argument. It is a high-capacity, consensus-oriented polity where trust in public institutions and expertise is generally high. Precisely for that reason, it helps isolate heterogeneities in how citizens evaluate delegation, potentially increasing the inferential leverage of our findings. Our claim is not that Finns view experts as partisan in the aggregate, but that a *subset of voters*—especially those far from the governing coalition—infer alignment when expert bodies advise, are appointed by, or implement the agenda of incumbents. Anecdotal evidence from the COVID-19 period illustrates this pattern: despite high average trust, confidence in official expert guidance varied by party sympathy, with skepticism concentrated among out-partisans while co-partisans remained supportive. In our framework, such heterogeneities matter because these voters evaluate delegation as a trade-off: a perceived governance-quality gain versus an ideological loss and reduced electoral accountability. The formal model makes this mechanism explicit and yields the core prediction we test: even in a high-trust environment, support for delegation declines with ideological distance from government when experts are perceived as government-aligned; the effect attenuates when experts are seen as neutral; and it is uniformly lower when the loss of accountability looms large. Finland therefore allows us to show that the observed pattern is driven by a subset of voters rather than by generalized anti-expert sentiment. Finally, our question sits at the intersection of realist views of mass politics (Achen and Bartels 2016) and critiques of the administrative/technocratic state (**Hamburger2014**; **Glennon2014**; **Majone1994**): when, and for which *subset of voters*, does delegating authority to unelected experts substitute for electoral accountability rather than complement it?

2 Theory

Democratic governance typically balances technocratic delegation against democratic accountability. Technocratic delegation refers to entrusting policy authority to experts or non-partisan institutions insulated from direct electoral control. Examples include independent central banks, regulatory agencies, or constitutional courts staffed by specialists. Such delegation is justified by the promise of neutral competence and long-term policy stability, but it inherently trades off responsiveness to the electorate. In other words, empowering the experts may improve technocratic quality at the cost of reducing the public's direct say in decision-making (**Caramani2023**). This tension is well documented: technocratic policy-making can dilute traditional accountability, since decisions occur outside the arena of partisan competition and popular oversight (**BertsouCaramani2020**). Democratic accountability, by contrast, requires that those who make policy are answerable to voters through elections and representative institutions. The crux of the issue is that what incumbents defend as neutral expertise, electoral losers may perceive as unaccountable elite rule. Importantly, institutional independence need not imply neutrality.

Evidence from U.S. monetary policy shows that an ostensibly technocratic, insulated actor like the Federal Reserve can behave as an "independent but not indifferent" conditional inflation hawk, shifting policy in ways that advantage one partisan bloc (Clark and Arel-Bundock 2013). This pattern underscores our core claim: delegation can acquire an ideological valence that voters perceive and react to. Thus, a central claim of our theory is that electoral losers' consent to delegation hinges on whether "neutral" institutions are *seen* as truly impartial or as ideologically aligned agents of the winners. Losers' consent is crucial for democratic stability: those who lose an election must still accept the legitimacy of the system and trust that their interests will be protected in opposition (**AndersonEtAl2005**). Typically, this is easier when independent institutions (courts, oversight bodies, expert agencies) serve as credible guardians of fair play. However, when losers suspect that

these institutions are in fact partisan—stacked with or naturally sympathetic to the incumbent coalition's ideology—their willingness to consent to delegation plummets. In effect, the losers no longer regard technocratic bodies as neutral arbiters but rather as extensions of the ruling bloc. Delegation under these conditions appears to them as a circumvention of democracy: policy being set by unelected actors who covertly advance the incumbents' program. Losers will thus resist ceding authority to such bodies, invoking the need for accountability and the "will of the people" to counter what they view as a biased technocracy.

Our argument is grounded in several streams of research. First, in polarized polities, even nominally non-partisan institutions become perceived in partisan terms. Polarization—the deep ideological divide between political camps—undermines any shared baseline of trust in institutions. Svolik (2019) demonstrates that intense polarization "undermines the public's ability to serve as a democratic check," as voters become willing to trade off democratic principles for partisan interests. In such an environment, each side suspects that ostensibly neutral referees (be it the judiciary, civil service, or expert regulators) covertly favor their opponents. Empirically, attitudes toward democratic institutions themselves have grown increasingly sorted by partisan identity. Claassen et al. (2025), for example, show that in countries led by right-wing populists (Hungary, Poland, Brazil), supporters of the incumbent right exhibit markedly lower support for liberal-democratic checks and balances, whereas the opposing camp (the electoral losers) places greater value on those checks. The key insight is that polarization produces mirror-image perceptions: *winners may dismiss certain constraints as nuisances, while losers champion them—but only so long as they believe those institutions can constrain the ruling side.* If instead the institutions are seen as captured by the ruling side, this pattern flips. Under hyper-polarization, institutions that should function as neutral checks are readily turned into, or at least seen as, unaccountable instruments of partisan or incumbent advantage. In the words of Lieberman et al. (2019, p. 471), polarization magnifies the partisan capture of independent institutions, eroding their legitimacy as neutral arbiters.

Given this dynamic, electoral losers will oppose technocratic delegation particularly when expert bodies carry an ideological valence aligned with incumbents. By ideological valence of expertise, we mean that expert institutions are not *perceived* as ideologically neutral but instead as tilting toward one end of the political spectrum. Expertise is never exercised in a political vacuum: economic technocrats, for instance, may predominantly subscribe to market-liberal orthodoxy (Clark and Arel-Bundock 2013; Clark, Golder, and Poast 2013); legal and bureaucratic elites might share the social outlook of the incumbent regime; scientific experts might prioritize values associated with one side of the cultural divide. In highly polarized contexts, these associations become highly salient. Losers come to view the "independent" central bank as effectively partisan (e.g. favoring austerity aligned with the government's ideology), or the judiciary as packed with judges loyal to the ruling party. As a result, what might superficially be a technocratic policy—say, an impartial public-health directive or a monetary tightening—is interpreted through a partisan lens. Perceived ideological bias in technocratic institutions thus short-circuits losers' trust. Rather than seeing delegation as securing unbiased expertise, losers see it as entrenching the incumbent coalition's preferences behind a facade of objectivity.

Moreover, partisans often apply a double standard to "neutral" oversight: support for procedural checks is highest when those checks constrain the out-party and softens when they constrain co-partisans (Svolik 2019; Kingzette et al. 2021). This contingency is consistent with the realist view that group identity and performance considerations, rather than abstract proceduralism, structure mass attitudes (Achen and Bartels 2016). In short, both winners and losers tend to champion institutional checks when those checks serve their partisan interests and to discount them when they do not. This pattern implies that an electoral loser's professed demand for accountability may mask a concern with policy outcomes: when their side is out of power, they are most likely to

decry "unelected bureaucrats" or "activist judges" when those actors are perceived as aligned with the rival camp. Our theory links this demand-side asymmetry to work on democratic backsliding: just as incumbents may erode checks to entrench power, oppositions can withdraw support from institutions they deem compromised. In both cases, commitment to democratic rules becomes contingent on who controls the levers of state authority (Waldner and Lust 2018).

We argue that opposition to technocratic delegation will be most acute under two conditions. First, when political polarization and partisan identity are strong. In a polarized environment, mutual mistrust runs high and even independent institutions are painted in red or blue. High affective partisan identification means citizens are less likely to tolerate policies made outside electoral contest, since compromise with the other side might be seen as a loss. Under such polarization, the basic requirement for losers' consent—confidence that the system treats sides fairly—is in short supply. Second, when incumbents have in fact politicized or captured nominally technocratic institutions. Incumbent governments frequently use appointments and institutional reforms to bias ostensibly independent bodies in their favor, especially during episodes of democratic backsliding (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019). Examples abound: packing supreme courts, tilting election commissions, staffing central bank boards with ideologically like-minded experts. These actions do not go unnoticed by the opposition. On the contrary, they become focal points of political conflict. An opposition that sees, say, the electoral commission openly favoring the ruling party will stridently object to any further empowerment of that commission. In new or fragile democracies, losing parties sometimes even refuse to recognize referees (for example, boycotting a biased election commission or constitutional court) precisely because they view them as tools of the incumbents. Thus, where the integrity of technocratic institutions is compromised, losers respond by rejecting those institutions' authority.

Importantly, our theory does not claim that electoral losers inherently oppose expert rule *per se*. Rather, the support or opposition of losers toward technocratic delegation is conditional on the perceived neutrality of expertise relative to partisan competition. In contexts where expert institutions are broadly trusted across the spectrum, losers may willingly delegate decisions to them—indeed, historically, opposition parties often support strengthening independent authorities as a way to constrain powerful executives (Keefer and Stasavage 2003). Likewise, survey evidence suggests that citizens who feel alienated from partisan politics (i.e., "structural losers") can exhibit higher support for technocratic governance as an alternative to dysfunctional party competition (**BertsouCaramani2020**). However, those scenarios presume that expertise stands apart from partisan ideology. Our contribution is to theorize what happens when that presumption breaks down. When expertise is perceived as ideologically aligned, delegation no longer offers a neutral solution. To the contrary, it appears as a mechanism for the ruling coalition to lock in its preferences without democratic contest. Under such conditions, we predict that electoral losers will frame technocratic delegation as illegitimate and resist it. They will call instead for decisions to be returned to "the people" (often via elections or referendums) where the opposition has a fighting chance. In short, when expert institutions are ideologically aligned with incumbents, opposition actors interpret technocratic delegation as partisan entrenchment and respond by reasserting democratic accountability through popular control.

This theoretical logic yields several observable implications. We would expect, for instance, that losers' resistance to delegation is heightened in highly polarized, ideologically sorted party systems, and during periods of intense policy conflict between government and opposition. Indeed, our framework helps explain why populist movements (often composed of "losers" of globalization or of recent elections) frequently target technocratic institutions as part of a corrupt establishment (**Caramani2023**). Conversely, in consensus-oriented or depolarized settings, or where technocratic bodies enjoy cross-partisan legitimacy, we should see less of this loser's backlash. Ultimately, our

theory underscores a paradox of contemporary democracy: institutions designed as impartial checks can sustain democratic stability only if they are broadly seen as impartial. If they come to be viewed as the ideological instruments of those in power, the very actors who most need to accept them—the electoral losers—may withdraw their consent, imperiling the delicate balance between expertise and democracy.

3 Formal Model: A Voter's Trade-Off: Technocratic Delegation vs. Electoral Accountability

Consider a one–dimensional policy space $[0, 1]$. A voter i has ideal point $\theta_i \in [0, 1]$. The governing coalition ("government") has position $\theta_g \in [0, 1]$. A technocratic institution ("experts") has perceived position $\theta_e \in [0, 1]$.

Distance and alignment. Define voter–government distance

$$d_i \;\equiv\; |\theta_i - \theta_g| \in [0, 1],$$

which corresponds to our empirical measure `gov_distance_w_01`. Perceived expert *alignment* with government is summarized by $\alpha \in [0, 1]$ via

$$\theta_e(\alpha) \;=\; \alpha\,\theta_g + (1 - \alpha)\,\bar{\theta},$$

where $\bar{\theta}$ is a non–partisan reference (e.g., a technocratic consensus or the median policy). Full alignment means $\alpha = 1$ (so $\theta_e = \theta_g$); lower α implies more neutral experts.

Sequence. Voter i chooses between retaining *electoral accountability* (A) or *delegating* to experts (D). Under D, policy is set at $\theta_e(\alpha)$ by unelected experts. Under A, electoral control ultimately delivers policy responsive to voters. For tractability, we take the long–run accountable outcome for voter i as $\theta_A = \theta_i$.[1]

Preferences. Utility is spatial with a technocratic valence bonus $B \geq 0$ and an irreversibility (or loss–of–accountability) penalty $\lambda \geq 0$ under delegation:

$$\begin{aligned} U_i(A) &= -(\theta_i - \theta_A)^2 \;=\; 0, \\ U_i(D) &= -(\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha))^2 \;+\; B \;-\; \lambda. \end{aligned}$$

Here B captures expected performance advantage from experts; λ captures the asymmetric difficulty of reversing delegation (loss of electoral control).

Decision rule. Voter i supports delegation iff $U_i(D) > U_i(A)$, i.e.

$$B \;-\; \lambda \;>\; \big(\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha)\big)^2. \tag{1}$$

Equivalently, define the *required valence* for delegation,

$$B_i^\star(\alpha, \lambda) \;\equiv\; \lambda + \big(\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha)\big)^2,$$

so that D is chosen iff $B > B_i^\star$.

[1] A more general formulation lets $\theta_A = \phi\,\theta_i + (1 - \phi)\,\theta_g$ with $\phi \in (0, 1]$ measuring accountability effectiveness. All results below go through with $(\theta_i - \theta_e)^2$ replaced by $(\theta_i - \theta_e)^2 - (\theta_i - \theta_A)^2$.

Special case: fully aligned experts. If $\alpha = 1$ (experts perceived as government–aligned), then $\theta_e = \theta_g$ and

$$B \; - \; \lambda \; > \; d_i^2. \tag{2}$$

Hence delegation is strictly decreasing in d_i: distant ("loser") voters require larger B to accept delegation.

Comparative statics.

- **Distance effect.** For fixed (B, λ, α), delegation is (weakly) less likely as d_i grows. Under (2), the threshold is $d_i^\star(B, \lambda) = \sqrt{B - \lambda}$; if $d_i > d_i^\star$, voter i rejects delegation.
- **Valence effect.** For fixed (d_i, λ, α), delegation is more likely as B increases; $\partial \mathbf{1}\{D\}/\partial B \geq 0$.
- **Irreversibility.** For fixed (d_i, B, α), delegation is less likely as λ increases; $\partial \mathbf{1}\{D\}/\partial \lambda \leq 0$.
- **Perceived alignment.** Since $\theta_e(\alpha) = \alpha\theta_g + (1 - \alpha)\bar{\theta}$, the ideological loss under D is $L_i(\alpha) \equiv (\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha))^2$. If $\bar{\theta}$ lies weakly between θ_g and θ_i, then $L_i(\alpha)$ is (weakly) increasing in α; delegation becomes less likely as experts are perceived more aligned with government.

Propositions.

1. **Losers oppose aligned technocracy.** If $\alpha = 1$, there exists a cutoff $d_i^\star(B, \lambda) = \sqrt{B - \lambda}$ such that voter i supports delegation iff $d_i < d_i^\star$. Thus, for any fixed (B, λ) with $B > \lambda$, support for delegation is strictly decreasing in d_i.
2. **Neutral experts attenuate the distance penalty.** If $\alpha < 1$ and $\bar{\theta}$ is closer to θ_i than θ_g is, then $L_i(\alpha) < d_i^2$, so the required valence $B_i^\star(\alpha, \lambda)$ falls relative to the aligned case. Opposition voters may accept delegation when experts are perceived neutral, holding (B, λ) fixed.
3. **Asymmetry tightens the threshold.** For any $(\theta_i, \theta_g, \alpha)$ and B, there exists $\bar{\lambda}$ such that for all $\lambda \geq \bar{\lambda}$, (1) fails and voter i rejects delegation. Greater irreversibility (loss of electoral control) systematically depresses support for delegation.

Link to identification. Equation (2) delivers the empirical prediction that, when expert institutions are perceived as government–aligned, *support for delegation is decreasing in the normalized distance* d_i and increasing in perceived valence B, with attenuation when experts are viewed as neutral ($\alpha < 1$) and when λ is small. This maps one–for–one to our econometric specification with `gov_distance_w_01` as the main covariate and measures of institutional trust/competence as proxies for (B, α).

4 Empirical Section: Original Survey Data in Finland

1. Constructing `gov_distance_w_01`

The main independent variable is `gov_distance_w_01`, a respondent–government distance measure based on party–closeness ratings.

Let i index respondents and let $p \in G$ index parties in the governing coalition. From Q27, respondents rate their closeness to each parliamentary party on a 0–10 scale (code 12 = "don't know"). Values equal to 12 are set to missing.

Let $C_{ip} \in [0, 10]$ denote respondent i's closeness to party p. Let s_p be party p's seat count in the Eduskunta at the time of fieldwork (KOK = 48, PS = 46, RKP = 9, KD = 5), and define coalition seat weights

$$w_p \equiv \frac{s_p}{\sum_{q \in G} s_q} \,.$$

Because some respondents skip one or more government parties, weights are renormalized over the set of parties that respondent i rated:

$$\tilde{w}_{ip} \equiv \frac{w_p \, \mathbb{1}\{C_{ip} \text{ observed}\}}{\sum_{q \in G} w_q \, \mathbb{1}\{C_{iq} \text{ observed}\}} \,.$$

Seat–weighted coalition closeness is

$$\text{GovCloseness}_i \equiv \sum_{p \in G} \tilde{w}_{ip} \, C_{ip} \in [0, 10] \,.$$

This is scaled to $[0, 1]$ and complemented by a distance index:

$$\texttt{gov_closeness_w_01}_i \equiv \frac{\text{GovCloseness}_i}{10}, \qquad \texttt{gov_distance_w_01}_i \equiv 1 - \texttt{gov_closeness_w_01}_i \,.$$

By construction, larger `gov_distance_w_01` indicates greater distance from the governing coalition in the Q27 closeness space.

2. Estimation strategy

We estimate the association between support for technocratic delegation and ideological distance from the governing coalition using a linear specification that treats the 1–5 outcome as approximately continuous (ordered models are reported as robustness). Let $\texttt{techno5}_i$ denote respondent i's technocracy item and $\texttt{gov_distance_w_01}_i \in [0, 1]$ the normalized distance–to–government index. The baseline model is

$$\texttt{techno5}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \, \texttt{gov_distance_w_01}_i + \beta_2 \, \texttt{Q8_1}_i + \beta_3 \, \texttt{Q9_4}_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}' \, \mathbf{X}_i + \delta_{\text{region}(i)} + \varepsilon_i,$$

where $\texttt{Q8_1}_i$ captures democratic satisfaction, $\texttt{Q9_4}_i$ trust in Finnish politicians, $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes education, age, and gender, and $\delta_{\text{region}(i)}$ are region fixed effects. The coefficient of interest is β_1, which—under the formal model's assumptions—should be negative when expert institutions are perceived as aligned with the incumbent bloc. Ordered logit estimates of the same specification (with cutpoints in place of ε_i) yield substantively identical conclusions.

3. Predicted values

Figure 1 reports *marginal standardization* (average predicted values) of `techno5` across the full range of `gov_distance_w_01` holding the distribution of all covariates at their observed values. The solid line is the point prediction; the shaded band is the 95% confidence interval. The estimated relationship is negative and approximately monotonic: moving from full proximity to maximal distance lowers the predicted outcome from about 3.5 to about 2.8 on the 1–5 scale.

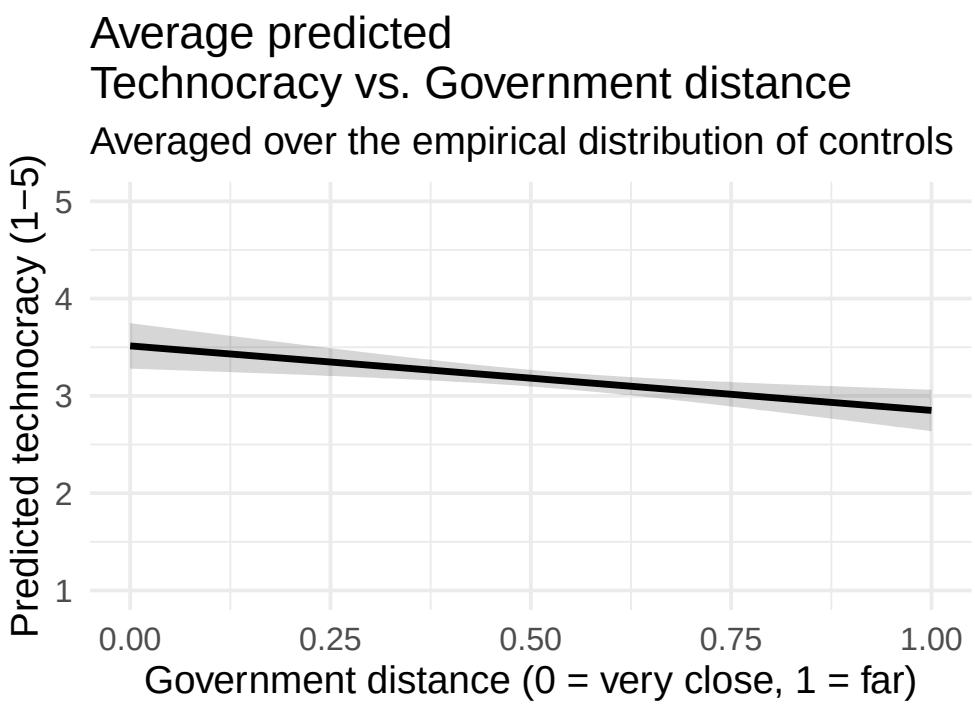

Figure 1: Average predicted technocracy vs. government distance (95% CIs).

4. Substantive interpretation and link to theory

The formal model implies that delegation is chosen only when the perceived governance–quality gain from expert rule exceeds the ideological and accountability costs of ceding control. When experts are perceived as government–aligned, the cost term grows with distance from the governing coalition, yielding a negative slope in `gov_distance_w_01`. The estimates match this prediction: respondents farther from the right–leaning Orpo coalition express *lower* support for technocratic delegation. A plausible reading in the Finnish context is that greater distance from the government largely identifies left–leaning respondents for whom "experts" are aligned with the center–right coalition; for this voters subset, delegation is evaluated as entrenching unfavorable policy under weaker electoral accountability. This pattern is compatible with losers endorsing checks and balances while rejecting depolitization: constraints that discipline incumbents without shifting authority away from elected politicians remain attractive, whereas technocratic delegation does not.

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